

# What is a Sukkah?

## ANCIENT ROOTS

1446-1405 BCE  
(2448-2487 IN THE HEBREW CALENDAR)

FOR FORTY YEARS, AS OUR ANCESTORS TRAVERSED THE SINAI DESERT PRIOR TO THEIR ENTRY INTO THE HOLY LAND, MIRACULOUS "CLOUDS OF GLORY" SURROUNDED AND HOVERED OVER THEM, SHIELDING THEM FROM THE DANGERS AND DISCOMFORTS OF THE DESERT. EVER SINCE, WE REMEMBER G-D'S KINDNESS AND REAFFIRM OUR TRUST IN HIS PROVIDENCE BY DWELLING IN A *SUKKAH* – A HUT OF TEMPORARY CONSTRUCTION WITH A ROOF-COVERING OF BRANCHES. THIS ROOF OF BRANCHES REMINDS US OF THE "CLOUDS OF GLORY" AND THE MIRACULOUS PROTECTION OUR ANCESTORS RECEIVED.

"YOU SHALL DWELL IN *SUKKOT* (I.E. PLURAL FORM OF *SUKKAH*) SEVEN DAYS, EVERY CITIZEN IN ISRAEL SHALL DWELL IN *SUKKOT*, SO THAT YOUR DESCENDANTS SHALL KNOW THAT IN *SUKKOT* I CAUSED THE CHILDREN OF ISRAEL TO DWELL WHEN I BROUGHT THEM OUT OF THE LAND OF EGYPT." (LEVITICUS, 23:42, 43)

WHEN THE ISRAELITES ARRIVED AT *SUKKOT*, THEY ENCAMPED THERE UNTIL THE FOLLOWING DAY. OUR SAGES TEACH THAT G-D MADE *SUKKOT* (I.E. PLURAL FORM OF *SUKKAH*) FOR THE CHILDREN OF ISRAEL THERE. SOME MAINTAIN THAT G-D PROVIDED THEM WITH ACTUAL BOOTHS FOR SHELTER; OTHERS SAY THAT THE *SUKKOT* G-D MADE FOR THEM CONSISTED OF SEVEN CLOUDS OF GLORY WHICH ENVELOPED THEM AND SERVED AS THEIR PROTECTION.

ONE CLOUD WAS PLACED UNDER THEIR FEET LIKE A CARPET, ONE WAS ABOVE THEIR HEADS LIKE A SHELTER, FOUR ENCIRCLED THEM FROM EACH SIDE, AND THE SEVENTH CLOUD WENT BEFORE THEM TO SHOW THEM THE WAY. ALL ISRAEL DWELLED IN ONE *SUKKAH* – THE *SUKKAH* OF THE CLOUDS OF GLORY. OUR SAGES SAY, "BOTH VIEWS ARE THE WORDS OF THE LIVING G-D." AT FIRST, HE MADE ACTUAL BOOTHS FOR THEM, AND THEN – IN REWARD FOR FORSAKING THEIR HOMES IN EGYPT, AND FOR HAVING DWELLED IN TEMPORARY *SUKKOT*, WITHOUT COMPLAINING TO G-D – THE CHILDREN OF ISRAEL MERITED THAT G-D SHOULD SURROUND THEM WITH HIS CLOUDS OF GLORY.

### BUT WHY THE HUTS?

G-D COULD SURELY HAVE PERFORMED ANOTHER MIRACLE FOR ISRAEL AND ENABLED THEM TO DWELL IN PERMANENT HOMES IN THE WILDERNESS, JUST AS HE ENABLED THEM TO DWELL IN THE MIRACULOUS *SUKKAH* FORMED BY HIS CLOUDS OF GLORY. IS THERE ANYTHING THAT IS BEYOND HIS ABILITY?! WHY DID HE SETTLE THEM IN TEMPORARY DWELLINGS WHEN THEY ENCAMPED AT *SUKKOT*? SO THAT THE GENERATION THAT HAD BEEN REDEEMED, AS WELL AS ALL THE GENERATIONS TO COME, WOULD KNOW THAT THERE IS NO ENDURING DWELLING OTHER THAN THAT PROVIDED BY G-D.

## WHAT ARE THOSE BRANCHES AND LEMON LIKE FRUIT?!?



ON EVERY DAY OF THE HOLIDAY OF *SUKKOT* (WITH THE EXCEPTION OF *SHABBAT, THE SABBATH*), THERE'S A *MITZVAH* TO TAKE THE "FOUR KINDS"—A *LULAV* (DATE PALM FROND), AN *ETROG* (CITRON), AT LEAST THREE *HADASSIM* (MYRTLE BRANCHES) AND TWO *ARAVOT* (WILLOW BRANCHES). IN THE WORDS OF THE VERSE (LEVITICUS 23:40), "YOU SHALL TAKE FOR YOURSELVES ON THE FIRST DAY THE FRUIT OF THE HADAR TREE [CITRON], DATE PALM FRONDS, A BRANCH OF A BRAIDED TREE, AND WILLOWS OF THE BROOK, AND YOU SHALL REJOICE BEFORE THE L RD YOUR G-D FOR A SEVEN DAY PERIOD."

THE *MITZVAH* (COMMANDMENT) OF THE *LULAV* AND *ETROG* SYMBOLIZES THE INTRINSIC UNITY OF THE JEWISH PEOPLE. THE FULFILLMENT OF THIS *MITZVAH* REQUIRES US TO HOLD TOGETHER EITHER FRUIT OR BRANCHES FROM FOUR DIFFERENT SPECIES OF TREES – THE DATE PALM (*LULAV*), THE MYRTLE (*HADAS*), THE WILLOW (*ARAVOS*), AND THE *CITRON* (*ETROG*). THESE FOUR SPECIES ARE NOTICEABLY DIFFERENT FROM ONE ANOTHER. THE *ETROG* HAS BOTH A PLEASANT TASTE AND A PLEASANT FRAGRANCE. THE FRUIT OF THE TREE FROM WHICH THE *LULAV* IS TAKEN, THE DATE, HAS A PLEASANT TASTE, BUT NO FRAGRANCE. THE MYRTLE HAS A PLEASANT FRAGRANCE BUT NO TASTE, AND THE WILLOW HAS NEITHER FRAGRANCE NOR PLEASANT TASTE.

TASTE SYMBOLIZES TORAH STUDY, BECAUSE UNDERSTANDING TORAH GIVES US A CONCRETE PLEASURE, SIMILAR TO THE SENSATION OF EXPERIENCING A PLEASING FLAVOR. SMELL SYMBOLIZES THE FULFILLMENT OF *MITZVOT* (COMMANDMENTS), BECAUSE THE QUALITY WHICH USUALLY MOTIVATES US TO FULFILL THEM IS AN UNQUESTIONING ACCEPTANCE OF THE YOKE OF HEAVEN. SINCE WE OFTEN DO NOT UNDERSTAND THE REASONS FOR THE *MITZVOT*, THEIR OBSERVANCE MAY BE LESS TANGIBLY GRATIFYING THAN TORAH STUDY IS, IN MUCH THE SAME WAY THAT SMELLING SOMETHING IS LESS PALPABLY GRATIFYING THAN TASTING IT.

AN EXTENSION OF THIS SYMBOLISM ENABLES US TO SEE EACH OF THE FOUR SPECIES AS REPRESENTING A DIFFERENT TYPE OF INDIVIDUALS. THE *ETROG* REPRESENTS A PERSON WHO STUDIES TORAH AND FULFILLS THE *MITZVOT*, THE *LULAV* REPRESENTS ONE WHO STUDIES TORAH BUT DOES NOT PERFORM *MITZVOS*, THE MYRTLE REPRESENTS ONE WHO FULFILLS *MITZVOT* BUT DOES NOT STUDY TORAH, AND THE WILLOW REPRESENTS A JEW WHO NEITHER STUDIES TORAH NOR OBSERVES *MITZVOT*.

### FULFILLMENT DEPENDS ON ONE'S CONNECTION WITH THEIR FELLOW PERSON

THE *MITZVAH* OF THE *LULAV* AND *ETROG* DEMONSTRATES THAT NO INDIVIDUAL CAN ATTAIN FULFILLMENT UNLESS THEY ARE WILLING TO GO BEYOND THEMSELVES AND JOIN TOGETHER WITH THEIR FELLOW PERSON. EVEN THE *ETROG*, THE SPECIES WHICH SYMBOLIZES BOTH THE VIRTUES OF TORAH STUDY AND OBSERVANCE OF THE *MITZVOT*, CANNOT BE USED FOR THE COMMANDMENT ON THE HOLIDAY OF *SUKKOT* UNLESS IT IS TAKEN IN HAND AND HELD TOGETHER WITH THE HUMBLE WILLOW. BY THE SAME TOKEN, NO MATTER HOW MUCH WE DEVELOP OURSELVES AS INDIVIDUALS, WE CANNOT REACH OUR TRUE POTENTIAL WITHOUT THE HELP OF OTHERS. THE UNITY OF OUR PEOPLE AS A WHOLE IS AN INDISPENSABLE INGREDIENT IN THE GROWTH AND PROGRESS OF EVERY INDIVIDUAL.

### GROWING FROM OUR CONTACT WITH OTHERS

THE MOTIF OF UNITY IS ALSO REFLECTED IN THE *ETROG*. INDEED, BECAUSE THE *ETROG* REPRESENTS A CATEGORY OF PEOPLE WHOSE POTENTIAL FOR ACHIEVEMENT IS GREATER THAN THAT OF OTHERS, ITS EMPHASIS ON UNITY MUST BE GREATER. THE *ETROG* EXPRESSES THE CONCEPT OF UNITY BY VIRTUE OF THE FACT THAT IT GROWS ON THE TREE FOR AN ENTIRE CALENDAR YEAR, AND IS EXPOSED TO ALL THE SEASONAL VARIATIONS AND CHANGES OF CLIMATE. NOT ONLY DOES THE *ETROG* WITHSTAND ALL THESE INFLUENCES, BUT IT RESPONDS POSITIVELY TO THEM; EACH OF THESE INFLUENCES CONTRIBUTES TO ITS GROWTH. WE MUST LEARN FROM THE *ESROG*, AND NOT MERELY TOLERATE PEOPLE OF ALL KINDS, INCLUDING THOSE WITH CHARACTERS AND PERSONALITIES VERY DIFFERENT FROM OUR OWN, BUT ACTUALLY GROW THROUGH CONTACT WITH THEIR DIVERGENT PERSPECTIVES. AS THE *MISHNAH* TEACHES, "WHO IS WISE? – ONE WHO LEARNS FROM EVERY PERSON."